

Q I have heard of the cordocentesis test. Should I be having it?

Like CVS and amniocentesis, this test detects chromosomal abnormalities. It can be performed after 18 weeks of pregnancy and is most commonly done if the other tests have not provided a reliable diagnosis. It is conducted in the same way as an amniocentesis, but with this test a tiny sample of the umbilical cord is taken. The results are usually available within three days. Careful consideration needs to be given before any of the diagnostic tests.

Q Will I be able to drive after I've had an invasive procedure? Can I go right back to work?

Whether you've had CVS or an amniocentesis, it's a good idea to have someone drive you home afterward. Although there are no risks involved with driving, you may feel shaky and experience some stomach cramping for a few hours, which can make driving uncomfortable. You'll be asked to rest for 24 hours, which means you should certainly take the following day off from work, and then take it easy for the next few days. Whether or not you take more time off depends upon your job; you should avoid doing any strenuous activity and any heavy lifting.

Q How quickly will I get the test results? How will they be given to me?

Processes differ from doctor to doctor, but in many cases you will be offered the option of having the results of the three main chromosomal abnormality tests (Down, Edwards', and Patau's syndromes, see box right) within two to three working days—this is called the Rapid Test, and you may have to pay for it. The results of a full chromosomal analysis (known as full karyotyping) and genetic and blood analysis will usually take two to three weeks. You'll be given the option of finding out the results on the telephone or face to face (in both cases your doctor will write to you afterward confirming what he or she has told you). Remember that you have had these tests because you are considered at "high risk" of

your baby being born with genetic abnormalities, which means you may be faced with difficult news about your baby's health. However you choose to receive the results, make sure someone is with you to support you if necessary.

Q What happens if my test confirms that my baby has a genetic or chromosomal abnormality?

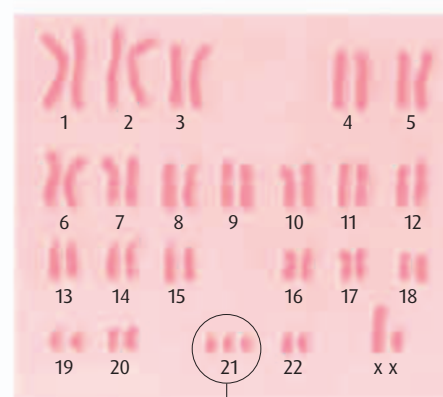
Once you have absorbed the initial diagnosis, your doctor will arrange another appointment for you to talk through the options in more detail if you need to. Make sure you understand the results in layman's terms—keep asking for clarification until you do. Some of the main things to consider are: whether the condition can be treated while your baby is still in the

uterus, or when she is born; what type of special needs your baby might have and to what extent; and will the condition be life limiting, and, if so, what is the baby's life-expectancy. There is no doubt that these are questions no prospective parent wants to ask. Make a list and take someone with you to the appointment who can support you and be a second set of ears to hear what you're being told. Depending upon the diagnosis, you may be offered a termination, although ending a pregnancy is a huge and emotional decision. Take your time. You won't have to make a decision there and then. Your doctor will offer you counseling to help you to come to terms with the situation before you do. Accept the offer if you think talking to an independent person will help you. In the end, though, no one but you can make the decision about what is right for your family. Surround yourself with people who will love and support you through your decision.

Q I know that Trisomy 21 is another term for Down syndrome, but what are Trisomy 13 and Trisomy 18?

Chromosomal abnormalities occur when there are either too few or too many of a specific chromosome. There are hundreds that are incompatible with life, meaning the pregnancy might end or the baby might survive for only a short time after birth.

All three of these conditions relate to chromosomal abnormalities. Healthy humans have 23 pairs of chromosomes, each numbered 1 to 23. Occasionally, a baby develops with an extra chromosome on one of the pairs, making a group of three (trisomy). Trisomy 21 (Down syndrome) means that there is an extra chromosome 21. Trisomy 18 indicates an extra chromosome 18, resulting in Edwards' syndrome; Trisomy 13 results in Patau's syndrome. Edwards' and Patau's syndrome are both extremely rare but life-limiting conditions, in which the baby is born with severe neurological and physical abnormalities. In either case babies aren't expected to live for more than a few days after birth. Both CVS and amniocentesis can detect whether or not your baby has any of these extra chromosomes.



Chromosomal abnormalities When an abnormality is found, it can be an error in the number or structure of the chromosomes or a problem with a gene. This can be caused by various factors.